

Victorian Gothic

In Britain, the Gothic Revival reached its full flowering through Victorian buildings of the mid-19th century, but its roots were considerably older. Horace Walpole, 4th earl of Orford (1717–97), art historian and politician, had been one of the first to revive the Gothic style. Starting in 1749, he spent nearly 30 years building the fanciful, heavily adorned Strawberry Hill House in Middlesex (opposite). Other early British champions of Gothic included Robert Adam's rival, James Wyatt (1746–1813); his design for Ashridge Park in Hertfordshire, begun in 1806, features a huge central hall that imitates a medieval great hall. After an apprenticeship with Gilbert Scott, George Edmund Street (1824–81) became a leading practitioner of the Victorian Gothic Revival, known especially as the designer of the Royal Courts of Justice in London. Street made more than 3,000 drawings of his design, and construction took 11 years from 1873. The massive white building is reminiscent of French 13th-century cathedrals and châteaux, dominated by soaring pitched roofs, pointed arches, towers and half-towers.

